

Germany

Ratio: 3:5 **Adopted:** May 23, 1949 **Usage:** National and Civil

The colors of the German flag were taken from the uniforms of German soldiers during the Napoleonic Wars



The flag was first adopted in 1848.

The flag was officially adopted for the republic in 1919

Europe



In 1919 the German Empire became a republic. In 1949 it was divided into East and West **Germany**, and in 1990 the two halves reunited.

Until the 19th century, Germany was a collection of feudal states. In 1848 an attempt was made to unite them, and although no union was established, a flag was produced. This was a black, red, and gold horizontal tricolor. The colors were taken from the uniforms of the German soldiers in the Napoleonic Wars in the late 18th century.

THE GERMAN EMPIRE

Most of the states finally united into the German Empire in 1871, but instead of retaining the black, red and gold flag, the rival Bismarck tricolor of black, white, and red was adopted. This was a combination of the red of the Hanseatic League and

the black and white of Prussia, of which Bismarck was Chancellor.

THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC

After Germany's defeat in the First World War a republic was declared in 1919 and the black, red, and gold flag returned. Its revival was short-lived and in 1933, when the Nazi government came to power they restored the imperial colors and made their party flag, the *Hakenkreuz*, the national flag.

After World War II, both German states reverted to using the black, red, and gold tricolor, but East Germany added its coat of arms. Since reunification, the plain tricolor has been used.